

Fabric Relaxation, Spreading and Cutting

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Relaxation before spreading

Fabric arriving on rolls is under tension from finishing and winding. Cutting it before that tension is released produces panels that shrink after sewing and fail measurement checks at final inspection.

Every roll must be opened, laid flat and relaxed before spreading. Relaxation time depends on the fabric:

Fabric	Relaxation time	Applies to
Cotton jersey and pique	24 hours	GAR-001, GAR-002
Cotton poplin and shirting	12 hours	GAR-003, GAR-008
Fleece	24 hours	GAR-004
Rayon and viscose	24 hours	GAR-005
Denim	48 hours	GAR-006
Polyester and performance knits	6 hours	GAR-007

Relaxation happens before the line can start. A cutting plan that ignores it will slip by a full day, and for denim by two days.

Spreading and shrinkage allowance

Spread tension must be neutral. Cotton knits are cut with a 3 percent shrinkage allowance, fleece with 4 percent, denim with 5 percent after one wash, and polyester with 1 percent. Rayon requires 4 percent and must never be spread more than 60 plies high because the lower plies distort.

Cutting tolerance and yield

Panel measurements are accepted within plus or minus 0.5 cm for body panels and plus or minus 0.3 cm for collars, cuffs and plackets. Cutting yield below 92 percent must be reported: it usually indicates a marker problem rather than an operator problem, and re-making the marker recovers more fabric than re-cutting.

Bundle release to the line

Cut panels are numbered, bundled by size and released to the line in size sequence. A line cannot begin sewing on a partial bundle set. Where fabric arrives late, the cutting room releases the largest size first because those panels take longest to sew.